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Chapter 15

Datafication and Postcolonial Discontinuities: Analyzing the Sociodigital Exploitation of Africa

Abstract: Digital microlending platforms have increasingly leveraged data extractivism, negatively impacting the privacy, financial resilience, and wellbeing of users in African countries. Although touted as a way to enable greater financial autonomy of users, these platforms entrap users through exorbitant loan terms and employ ‘debt-shaming’ tactics, which involve blackmail, harassment, defamation, doxxing, and threats of litigation to aid loan repayment. This chapter incorporates critical data perspectives to examine historical and present-day datafication, detailing how these practices perpetuate colonial ideals and harm users through sociodigital exploitation, a form of manipulation facilitated through and exacerbated by digital tools. This chapter also contributes an analysis of digital microlending in African countries, investigating harms committed by these platforms, detailing strategies consumers are using to subvert harmful practices, and enlisting policy measures instituted by governments and large tech companies to regulate digital microlending. The chapter concludes by exploring how indigenous African lending practices and philosophical values can reform digital microlending practices and inspire postcolonial digital lending systems.

Keywords: microfinance, digital lending, sociodigital exploitation, digital platforms, financial technology, datafication, Africa

Introduction

A burgeoning body of research has probed the correlation between present-day datafication practices and colonial-era exploitation.¹ Isin and Ruppert particularly note the distinct dynamics of datafication on communities in the Global South and how postcolonial governments adopted and adapted these practices. While datafication practices have accompanied colonization and still pervade the current period of post-colonialism, the introduction of digital technologies, particularly AI, has established

¹ Mejias and Couldry, “Datafication”; Thatcher, O’Sullivan, and Mahmoudi, “Data Colonialism through Accumulation by Dispossession,” 990–1006; Isin and Ruppert, “Data’s Empire,” 207–227; Ricaurte, “Data Epistemologies, the Coloniality of Power, and Resistance,” 350–365; Gray, “More Than Extraction.”

new norms for the collection, processing, use, and storage of data. This leads to the term ‘postcolonial discontinuities,’ which this chapter leverages to explore how former colonies contest, dismantle, and reimagine the social, political, economic, and cultural structures imposed by colonialism. In the context of datafication, while the goals of historical data practices may differ from present-day aims, these issues engender many harms associated with colonization, including human labor and natural resource exploitation, and generate new ones, such as widespread surveillance, cybersecurity risks, and personalized targeting.

The expansion of digital platforms across Africa, particularly those offering financial services to African consumers in countries such as Nigeria, Kenya, and Uganda, has led to an increase in datafication, impacting the privacy and well-being of users. While microcredit has been present on the continent for almost two decades, many of these loan apps grew in prominence during the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, which has continued to effect bleak economic impacts in many African countries. While touted as a way to enable greater financial autonomy, microlending platforms entrap users through exorbitant loan terms with extremely high interest rates (with APRs reaching 400 percent or greater) and short loan maturity dates. They also employ ‘debt-shaming’ tactics, which involve blackmail, harassment, defamation, doxxing, and threats of litigation, frequently using illegally obtained personal information to aid loan repayment.

This chapter begins by explaining the concept of datafication, detailing its impact on marginalized populations, potential implications for African countries, and how large tech companies are expanding these practices. It also introduces the terms ‘sociodigital marginalization’ and ‘sociodigital exploitation’ to delineate how digital technologies disenfranchise vulnerable populations and are leveraged to manipulate communities that are already disadvantaged due to their socioeconomic circumstances. This chapter also examines neocolonial data practices, detailing historic and present-day forms of datafication that have impacted countries in Africa and throughout the Global South. The origins of microlending and the current digital microlending ecosystem in Africa are also analyzed. This section of the chapter then concludes by examining traditional African lending practices to situate indigenous knowledge in financial practices.

Next, this chapter investigates how the rise of digital platforms, particularly microlending services, has impacted African consumers. The chapter begins with a landscape analysis of leading microlending platforms in Africa, examining their operational geographies, ownership structures, and business models. The subsequent case studies of these platforms situate their impact within historical data practices to understand how they exert power over users and extend colonial tactics. This section details user experiences with digital microlending and strategies consumers have employed to subvert harmful practices from these platforms. Finally, this section concludes by detailing policy measures leveraged by platforms and governments to regulate harmful digital microlending practices and the implications surrounding the adoption and enforcement of these regulations.

This chapter culminates by examining the broader implications of datafication in African contexts, given the increasing adoption of AI. This chapter engages in a broader discussion to explore how indigenous African philosophical frameworks can guide grassroots-driven justice measures amid intensifying datafication and algorithmization across the continent. By critically examining the technological infrastructures of digital microlending platforms in Africa and sociodigital changes resulting from the adoption of these systems, this chapter aims to probe how consumers can counteract the adverse effects of datafication and regain agency from digital platforms to guide equitable algorithmic outcomes.

Datafication

Datafication is the transformation of social aspects of human identity and behavior into data used for analysis, decision-making, personalization, and targeting. Much of this data is captured through consumer interactions with websites, mobile applications, and other digital services. Researchers examining this phenomenon have connected how this appropriation of data disproportionately marginalizes people experiencing poverty,² extends histories of colonialism,³ exacerbates surveillance of indigenous populations,⁴ and threatens the right to agency and sovereignty over data.⁵ A number of research papers have analyzed datafication in African contexts, detailing the power imbalances within international development projects that mostly benefit large corporations,⁶ examining regulatory measures that counter datafication practices,⁷ and scrutinizing the impact of the ‘data revolution’ on socioeconomic development efforts.⁸ Given the increasing interest in AI development globally, the adverse effects of datafication in African countries and other parts of the Global South will only increase as companies race to seek non-Western data sources to expand the capabilities of their large, generative AI models (often frequently referred to as ‘frontier’ or ‘foundation’ models). While datafication has emerged primarily to increase consumer ad targeting and improve content recommendations, these practices are increasingly being used in Africa to enable digital microlending services, in AI for ‘social good’ projects, and by governments and humanitarian aid agencies in refugee tracking.

2 Eubanks, *Automating Inequality*.

3 Couldry and Mejias, “Data Colonialism,” 336–349.

4 Cormack and Kukutai, “Indigenous Peoples, Data, and the Coloniality of Surveillance,” 121–141.

5 Walter et al., “Indigenous Data Sovereignty in the Era of Big Data and Open Data,” 143–156.

6 Taylor and Broeders, “In The Name of Development,” 229–237.

7 Gillwald et al., “Digital New Deal for Africa.”

8 Cieslik and Margócsy, “Datafication, Power and Control in Development,” 352–373.

The practices of big tech companies such as Amazon, Google, Meta (including subsidiaries, Facebook and Instagram), X (formerly Twitter), and Microsoft exacerbate datafication and help advance their services, monetize their platforms, and increase revenue in various ways. These datafication practices are implemented through surveillance, extraction, and labor exploitation. For example, social media platforms developed by these companies notoriously leverage datafication to enable ad revenue, and marketing practices from search engines developed by these companies leverage consumer search queries to engage in cross-site tracking and personalized ad targeting.⁹ Platforms such as Amazon Mechanical Turk, launched in November 2005, fueled early practices in datafication. This crowdsourcing platform provided researchers and companies with low-cost access to crowd workers who complete tasks such as image annotation, rating, transcription, surveys, and writing. Amazon Mechanical Turk also played a significant role in the development of notable machine learning benchmark datasets such as ImageNet, which developed a database of over 14 million images classified into 20,000 categories.¹⁰ The development of AI systems by large tech players and prominent AI companies such as OpenAI, Anthropic, and Midjourney has changed the datafication landscape, leveraging smaller players like Scale AI, Mighty AI, and Samasource as ‘data middlemen’ to further continue this cycle.

Sociodigital Marginalization and Exploitation

The term ‘sociodigital change,’ coined by Jörn Lengsfeld, refers to social changes triggered by the spread of digital information and communication technologies.¹¹ Adapting this definition, this article introduces and defines ‘sociodigital marginalization’ as the process by which individuals or groups are excluded from the benefits of digital technologies due to social factors like poverty, education, geographic location, race, ethnicity, gender, religion, and disability, as well as digital factors such as access to technology infrastructure, inaccessible user interfaces, and lack of digital literacy. These factors can lead to limited access to information, exclusion from digital services, and impacts on how people experience digital platforms and tools. Practices like datafication also heighten the effects of sociodigital marginalization, increasing discrimination and social inequalities among disenfranchised populations.¹²

Sociodigital exploitation is a byproduct of sociodigital marginalization, where manipulation is facilitated through and exacerbated by digital tools. Along with dark pat-

9 Schroedl, Kesari, and Neumeyer, “Personalized Ad Placement in Web Search”; Roesner, Kohno, and Wetherall, “Detecting and Defending Against {Third-Party} Tracking on the Web,” 155–168.

10 Deng et al., “Imagenet,” 248–255.

11 Lengsfeld. “Digital Era Framework.”

12 Leurs and Shepherd, “Datafication & Discrimination,” 211–231.

terns and other deceptive practices, factors such as digital literacy, financial vulnerability, inexperience with privacy measures, and a lack of effective governance processes can enable sociodigital exploitation. Within Africa, sociodigital exploitation is rampant through consumer interactions with social media platforms and is most prominent in the delivery of digital financial services such as microlending. Such exploitation is also reminiscent of historical disenfranchisement imposed on local populations by colonial actors, many of the effects of which are still present in formerly colonized nations. The increasing digitization of the world has significantly changed how humans adapt to the presence of technology in their daily lives and has had a profound impact on how people act and think among themselves and interact with each other.¹³ As sociodigital exploitation widens, this will inevitably shape how consumers interact with digital platforms, highlighting consequential implications for user agency and autonomy.

(Neo)colonial Data Practices

Historical (pre-digital) data extraction practices have centered around the exploitation of marginalized populations and can be traced back to colonial practices in the 1500s, which enabled empires in Europe to manage their respective colonies.¹⁴ Such practices also include the branding of enslaved Black people to identify their owners and which plantations they lived on.¹⁵ Enslaved people were often branded during capture and when sold to plantations. These brands could be sovereign crests of the slave ships that trafficked them, alphanumeric characters, or the initials of enslavers, and hot marking irons were used to place these brands on various body parts, including foreheads, arms, or chests.¹⁶ Colonial-era marginalization also increased the widespread deployment of biometric collection from local populations. The French empire routinely deployed forensic identification methods, such as fingerprinting, photographing, and detailed bodily feature descriptions in their colonies to enable their control of subjugated populations.¹⁷ The British fingerprinting program in colonial-era India, introduced in the 1870s, was primarily used for administrative purposes, such as contracts, government pensions, land deeds, debt bonds, and jail admission.¹⁸ This practice evolved into a wide-scale fingerprinting program used to track hiring,

¹³ Adolphs, “Digitization of the World.”

¹⁴ Cieslik and Margócsy, “Datafication, Power and Control in Development,” 352–373.

¹⁵ Kapoureلاكou, “‘Blackness’ is a Key Site Through Which Surveillance is Practiced, Narrated, and Enacted.”

¹⁶ Browne, “B@anding Blackness,” 89–130.

¹⁷ About, “Identités indigènes et police coloniale,” 280–301; Meyer and Berthélémy, “The Colonial Biometric Legacy at Heart of New EU Asylum System.”

¹⁸ Singha, “Settle, Mobilize, Verify,” 151–198.

exclude ex-convicts from employment, assist in pension disbursement, aid in army recruitment, and surveil members of nomadic communities.

Colonial administrations also leveraged data collected on local property and traded goods to impose taxes on indigenous communities despite the plundering of natural resources and exploitation of slave labor.¹⁹ In some cases, colonial regimes like the French negatively leveraged datafication to order indemnity payments on Haiti as compensation for 'lost' income from slave labor and the property of former plantation owners.²⁰ Many of these colonial-era practices pervade today and have severely impacted the ability of formerly colonized countries to be self-sufficient, pushing many further into debt and impeding socioeconomic development.²¹

Present-day datafication takes many forms and is quite prominent in the humanitarian aid sector, disproportionately impacting African countries. The practices include geospatial mapping,²² biometrics,²³ tracking of mobile phone networks,²⁴ survey distribution,²⁵ identity registries,²⁶ and a proliferation of mobile apps, many of which remain unused²⁷ or are forced onto refugees and asylum seekers.²⁸ Issues around datafication in humanitarian contexts are exacerbated by substandard data collection, improper data storage, and data privacy breaches.²⁹

The practice of collecting biometrics stems from colonial-era exploitation by the British in India³⁰ and continues to affect communities impacted by displacement and migration, particularly from agencies such as the UN Refugee Agency (UNHCR), the U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), and programs such as the EU's asylum database, EURODAC. In Africa, biometric collection of refugee data has been in place since at least 2007, with UNHCR conducting fingerprint and iris-scanning collection in Kenyan refugee camps.³¹ In 2012, UNHCR also introduced biometrics to aid in refugee registration in Liberia, the first in West Africa, and has used these services in South Sudan since 2013.³² The International Organization for Migration (IOM) has es-

¹⁹ Gardner, *Taxing Colonial Africa*.

²⁰ Woolfenden, "The Colonial Roots of Global South Debt."

²¹ Hickel et al., "Imperialist Appropriation in the World Economy."

²² Specht, *Mapping Crisis*.

²³ Holloway, Al Masri, and Abu Yahia, "Digital Identity, Biometrics and Inclusion in Humanitarian Responses to Refugee Crises"; Jacobsen, "Biometric Data Flows and Unintended Consequences of Counterterrorism," 619–652; Madianou, "Nonhuman Humanitarianism," 850–868.

²⁴ Aiken et al., "Machine Learning and Phone Data Can Improve Targeting of Humanitarian Aid," 864–870.

²⁵ Morrow et al., "Knowing Just in Time," 210–216; Mirca Madianou, "Technocolonialism."

²⁶ Hosein and Nyst, "Aiding Surveillance."

²⁷ Leurs and Smets, "Five Questions for Digital Migration Studies."

²⁸ Kocher, "Glitches in the Digitization of Asylum," 149; Amnesty International, "CBP One."

²⁹ Human Rights Watch, "UN Shared Rohingya Data Without Informed Consent."

³⁰ Singha, "Settle, Mobilize, Verify," 151–198.

³¹ Jacobsen, "New Forms of Intervention."

³² Delgado, "Where and How in Africa Is Biometrics Being Used?"

established biometric checkpoints, which capture fingerprints and facial scans at borders in at least sixteen African countries.³³

Digital Microlending in Africa

Digital microlending is a form of microcredit focused on providing short-term small loans to consumers through mobile phones.³⁴ These loans often help consumers handle daily living expenses, pay bills, and obtain business supplies. The development of the field of microcredit is credited to Nobel Peace Prize-winner Muhammad Yunus, a Bangladeshi economist who began experiments giving loans to families and women bamboo furniture makers in Bangladesh in the '70s, with the premise that small loans would significantly impact poor consumers positively.³⁵ These efforts evolved into Grameen Bank, which has disbursed almost \$38 billion in loans to borrowers worldwide, 97 percent of whom were women as of June 2024.³⁶ However, there is significant debate as to how successful microcredit has been in alleviating poverty in financially vulnerable communities due to high interest rates, short repayment terms, and the relatively insignificant sums lent.³⁷ Over the past decade, the introduction and broad adoption of mobile phones and the internet across Africa have increased consumer accessibility to digital services, including financial services like microlending.³⁸ GSMA, a nonprofit industry organization representing mobile network operators, estimates that there were 489 million unique mobile subscribers in sub-Saharan Africa in 2023, which is expected to grow to 692 million by 2030.³⁹

While bank account ownership in Africa has doubled since 2011 to 49 percent,⁴⁰ the usage of digital microlending is also driven by a lack of stable lending and formal credit systems.⁴¹ A significant driver of the adoption of digital microlending in Africa was the introduction of mobile money services pioneered by M-Pesa, a platform developed by Vodafone and Safaricom, prominent telecommunications network operators in African. The service provided users with access to formal banking services like deposits, transfers, bill pay, airtime purchases, and lending.⁴² Mobile money evolved

33 Weitzberg, "Passing As a Refugee."

34 Francis, Blumenstock, and Robinson, "Digital Credit," 1739–76.

35 Yunus, "Microcredit, Information Technology, and Poverty," 233.

36 Bank, "About Grameen Bank."

37 Kandie and Islam, "A New Era of Microfinance," 469–492.

38 Evans, "Connecting the Poor," 568–581; Kelikume, "Digital Financial Inclusion, Informal Economy and Poverty Reduction in Africa," 626–640.

39 GSMA, "The Mobile Economy Sub-Saharan Africa 2023."

40 World Bank, "Financial Inclusion in Sub-Saharan Africa—Overview."

41 Zins and Weill, "The Determinants of Financial Inclusion in Africa," 46–57.

42 Omwansa, "M-PESA," 475.

from exchanging mobile airtime for cash, which African consumers have practiced since at least the early 2000s.⁴³ Over the past decade, digital microlending has grown in prominence across the continent. According to Crunchbase, 164 consumer lending companies have been operating in Africa as of July 2025.⁴⁴ While 90⁴⁵ of these companies operate in the microlending space, there is no accurate accounting of the total number of digital microlending mobile apps operating in African countries. These apps primarily operate within the largest economies in Africa, including countries such as Egypt, Kenya, Morocco, Nigeria, and South Africa. They are operated by a wide range of domestic and international companies, including emerging startups, multinational telecommunications firms, and large banks.

African Indigenous Savings and Lending Practices

In Africa, the establishment of indigenous lending practices through formal credit institutions can be traced back to at least the 1700s.⁴⁶ While there is little published research analyzing the origin of informal credit practices in Africa through rotating savings and credit associations (ROSCAs) or informal saving groups (ISGs), evidence shows that these groups have existed since precolonial times.⁴⁷ Groups like these enable people to save funds collaboratively over specific time periods, allowing each member to rotate receiving loans from the pooled funds.⁴⁸ Throughout the continent, ROSCAs/ISGs operate quite similarly but vary in name, from *chamas* and *hagbad* in East Africa, *esusu* and *djanggi* in West Africa, *stokvel* and *chilimba* in Southern Africa, to *daret* in North Africa. These indigenous savings and lending practices are still in use today and are popular with members of the African diaspora.⁴⁹

Many of these practices are driven by indigenous African philosophies that value communality, social responsibility, and shared prosperity. *Ubuntu*, a value system that originated in southern Africa, emphasizes that personal good fortune is amplified by distributing wealth throughout society.⁵⁰ In Ìgbò philosophical thought, *Nmekọka* highlights group strength, directly translated in the Ìgbò language as “strength or power is found in the group or achieved in coming together.”⁵¹ Dada describes *Ọmọlú-*

43 Mwesigwa and Csíkszentmihályi, “Air/time Travel,” 1–21.

44 See Crunchbase, <https://www.crunchbase.com>

45 Crunchbase.

46 Austin, “Indigenous Credit Institutions in West Africa, c. 1750–c. 1960,” 93–159.

47 Ardener, “The Social And Economic Significance of the Contribution Club Among a Section of the Southern Ibom,” 128–142; Nwabughuogu, “The ‘Isusu,’” 46–58.

48 Besley, Coate, and Loury, “The Economics of Rotating Savings and Credit Associations,” 792–810.

49 Ibrahim, “Structured Savings and Asset Ownership.”

50 Khomba, “Redesigning the Balanced Scorecard Model.”

51 Chimakonam, “Integrative Humanism: Extensions and Clarifications.”

wàbí, a Yorùbá cultural concept, as a form of ‘public morality’ in which a person has “acquired a moral status that could qualify him as being virtuous.”⁵² In Swahili philosophy, *Harambee* emphasizes communal strength and group effort and translates as “let us pull together.”⁵³ Drawing from these philosophical foundations, there is an opportunity for microfinance institutions in Africa to learn from indigenous practices and restructure their lending models.

Case Studies of Digital Microlending in Africa

A growing amount of research has focused on examining the predatory side of digital microlending in Africa, which has increasingly leveraged datafication to harass and extort consumers.⁵⁴ To understand the broad landscape of digital microlending in Africa, this section analyzes prominent microlending platforms operating on the continent, examining their operational geographies, ownership structures, and business models. It also examines harmful practices conducted by these companies, policy measures incorporated by platforms and governments to regulate these practices, and how users are subverting these practices.

Microlending Platforms in Africa

Startups, banks, and telecommunications companies operate digital microlending platforms in Africa. Top microlending platforms include Branch (Nigeria, Kenya, Tanzania), Kuda (Nigeria), Carbon (Nigeria), Migo (Nigeria), Tala (Kenya), Umba (Kenya, Nigeria), and M-KOPA (Uganda, Nigeria, Ghana, Kenya, South Africa). Of the banks surveyed in the 2023 African Digital Banking Report, 48 percent offer digital lending services,⁵⁵ including Absa Bank, Access Bank, Bank of Kigali, Capitec Bank, First Bank of Nigeria, Guaranty Trust Bank, Stanbic, Standard Bank, United Bank for Africa, and Zenith Bank. A large number of telecommunications companies have also begun to leverage their mobile money services to expand their footprint within the digital lending ecosystem. MTN, the largest mobile network operator in Africa, operates MoMo, which allows users to obtain short-term loans, alongside buying airtime, data bundles,

52 Dada, “Aristotle and the Ọmọlúwàbí Ethos,” 1–28.

53 Ng’Ethe, “Politics, Ideology and the Underprivileged,” 150–170.

54 Mogaji and Nguyen, “The Dark Side of Mobile Money”; Munyendo, Acar, and Aviv, “Desperate Times Call for Desperate Measures,” 2304–2319; Achieng, “How Fintech Became the Gateway to Predatory Lending in Sub-Saharan Africa”; Macharia et al., “The Precarity of Mobile Loan Debt and Repayment Among Female Sex Workers in Nairobi, Kenya.”

55 African Banker, “African Digital Banking Transformation Report 2023.”

bill pay, online banking, and online shopping. Nigeria-based 9mobile operates Migo Loan, which provides loans to customers who have been active for at least ninety days and are eighteen years or older. They claim to disburse ‘quick loans’ from NGN 100–100k (\$0.06–62)⁵⁶ in sixty seconds, which have repayment terms of fourteen days at 15 percent interest. M-Pesa, the premier mobile money platform on the continent, operated by telcos Vodafone and Safaricom, also offers loans from KES 1,000 (\$7.75) to KES 1 million (\$7,752), with fees and interest equaling 9 percent.⁵⁷

However, these apps engage in concerning business practices. OKash, a digital micro-lending platform in Nigeria operated by Blueridge Microfinance Bank, has over 10 million downloads.⁵⁸ Their description on the Google Play Store states that their loan tenure (amount of time for loan repayment) is 91–365 days, with typical loan amounts from NGN 3,000 to NGN 1,000,000 (\$1.81–602) and a minimum interest rate of 3 to 15 percent, compounded monthly. This app has mandatory permissions for collecting users’ precise location and device ID and optional permissions for collecting contacts, calendars, photos, files, user payment information, and personal information (name, email address, address, phone number, user IDs). While the reasons for these permissions include ‘Fraud prevention, security, and compliance’ or ‘App functionality’ and ‘Analytics,’ much of the data within ‘optional’ permissions is collected as a part of the loan application process. Additionally, Google Play Store reviews of OKash (analyzed by the author in July 2024) indicate that the stated interest rate is misleading. For example, one user received a loan of NGN 4,000 (\$2.41), accompanied by interest of NGN 1,400 (\$0.84) for a thirty-day tenure, which is effectively a 35 percent interest rate, more than double the advertised maximum interest rate and three times lower than the advertised minimum loan tenure. Another consumer borrowed NGN 12,000 (\$7.22), accompanied by interest of NGN 3,420 (\$2.06), an interest rate of 28.5 percent. Another received a loan of NGN 40,000 (\$24.08), accompanied by interest of NGN 21,360 (\$12.86), an interest rate of 53.40 percent, which is three-and-a-half times the advertised maximum monthly interest rate OKash displays on the Google Play Store (15 percent). In 2022, the Nigerian government shut down OKash due to data privacy violations but reinstated the app after it received approval from the Nigerian Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission. However, recent reviews from the Google Play Store indicate that data privacy violations still occur, with users reporting receiving loan solicitation calls from multiple numbers despite attempting to delete their accounts or not proceeding in the application process.

⁵⁶ All of the figures and currency conversions (from Naira to USD and Kenyan Shillings to USD) in this section were computed in July 2024.

⁵⁷ M-PESA, “M-Shwari.”

⁵⁸ Google Play, “OKash.”

Harmful Practices in Digital Microlending

While social media and search engines have primarily been the main arbiters of datafication in digital ecosystems, these practices have permeated mobile applications, offering a variety of services to users in education, finance, healthcare, and dating.⁵⁹ Over the past decade, the emergence of digital platforms offering financial services to African consumers has leveraged datafication practices to negatively impact users. Given the precarious economic standing of loan platform users, they are forced to consent to exorbitant loan terms and share their personal data, including location, contact lists, and photo libraries. In order to recoup loans, these companies employ ‘debt-shaming,’ a tactic that involves leveraging collected personal data to conduct consumer doxxing, targeted harassment, and blackmail. Human agents operating on behalf of these companies leverage this data into a modern form of skip tracing, a practice of leveraging open-source and private information (property records, phone directories, court records, tax records, utility records, credit reports, and social media) to track debtors and force repayment. Reports have noted these agents spam borrowers’ contact lists, often labeling the borrower as a ‘hardened criminal,’ ‘wanted by management,’ or ‘fraudulent person’ in text messages.⁶⁰ Despite repaying loans or not even applying for a loan, users may be repeatedly contacted by these agents who have gained access to their personal contact data.

While governments in Africa (primarily Kenya and Nigeria) and mobile app store platforms like Google’s Play Store have begun to take regulatory action against offending platforms, these platforms continue to proliferate despite existing bans and regulatory efforts. Companies operating these microlending apps often establish shell companies or subsidiaries to obfuscate operations, which aids in their ability to set up loan apps rapidly. In some cases, these companies provide fake company director names, inactive emails, and false addresses on their company registration forms.⁶¹ In other cases, they fail to obtain proper licenses to operate legally in their respective countries. Reports have indicated that many of the companies behind these apps originate from crime syndicates operating in China,⁶² and countries like Nigeria have frequently raided the offices of companies running microlending platforms.⁶³ While regulatory environments across Africa are gradually improving their governance of loan apps, it is unclear how successful actions like fines and bans are against these compa-

59 De Ridder, “The Datafication of Intimacy,” 593–609; Pybus and Coté, “Did You Give Permission?” 1650–1668.

60 Kiruga, “This Lending App Publicly Shames You When You’re Late on Loan Payment”; Munyendo, Acar, and Aviv, “Desperate Times Call for Desperate Measures,” 2304–2319.

61 Hundeyin, “Suicide, Fraud and Phillips Consulting.”

62 Ngai, “Predatory Lending Apps Claim Victims Across Asia”; IANS, “Chinese Syndicates to Keep Hurting India Via Loan App Scams.”

63 Adelagun, “Nigeria’s Consumer Protection Agency Cracks Down on Digital Loan Firms.”

nies. In 2022, Sokoloan, a prominent microlender in Nigeria, avoided a lien placed by the Nigerian government by changing its bank account information.⁶⁴ As Africans get increasingly online while economic conditions continue to worsen in countries such as Nigeria, Ghana, and Zimbabwe, consumers could be pushed toward these harmful apps.

User Experiences with Microlending

Traditionally, microcredit utilized group accountability dynamics to encourage repayment, awarding loans to people who belonged to the same social groups.⁶⁵ However, modern-day microlending practices leverage this collective responsibility in debt-shaming to encourage repayment by reaching out to the borrower's contacts, many of whom are likely to be family members, friends, and colleagues, despite the harm caused by this process. A significant part of 'debt-shaming' approaches focuses on impacting users' reputations and morale, incorporating tactics such as sharing doctored explicit photos, obituaries, and wanted posters with borrower contacts. Users have also reported losing jobs and 'bringing shame' to their families because of these practices. These issues impact consumers across regions in the Global South outside of Africa, including Latin America and Asia, with the BBC reporting at least sixty suicides in India resulting from harassment by loan app agents⁶⁶ and researchers detailing how young Chinese women take naked selfies as collateral for loan security.⁶⁷ In countries like Kenya that have established credit scoring systems, consumers have reported being blacklisted by credit bureaus, which prevents them from taking further loans.⁶⁸ In other cases, users experience 'debt snowballing,' where they end up trapped in debt cycles, taking loans from multiple apps to aid repayment for previous loans.⁶⁹

⁶⁴ Hundeyin, "Suicide, Fraud and Phillips Consulting."

⁶⁵ Dunford, "Credit Unions and Rural Banks Reaching Down and Out to the Rural Poor Through Group-Based Microfinance," 107–124.

⁶⁶ Agarwal, Sonar, and Hegarty, "Inside the Deadly Instant Loan App Scam that Blackmails with Nudes."

⁶⁷ Liu and Keane, "Naked Loan Selfies," 3616–3633.

⁶⁸ Macharia et al., "The Precarity of Mobile Loan Debt and Repayment Among Female Sex Workers in Nairobi, Kenya."

⁶⁹ Kiruga, "This Lending App Publicly Shames You when You're Late on Loan Payment"; Olaigbe, "Loan Apps Ruined Their Reputations."

User Subversion in Digital Microlending

Consumers are subverting harmful loan repayment practices by leveraging online support groups and crowdsourcing debt-avoidance strategies. *Rest of World* reports how Nigerians leverage Facebook groups to resist harassment and avoid loan repayment.⁷⁰ Between February and March 2023, they tracked eleven Facebook groups with memberships from two hundred to 46 thousand people. Before regulatory protections restricted the types of data loan apps could access, many consumers also configured their device permissions to prevent access to their contacts, photo libraries, and location. Other users have leveraged bulk-buying of SIM cards to create multiple loan accounts on different apps linked to separate phone numbers. Users sometimes use fake names/identity cards to prevent credit checks and create multiple accounts. To address issues with loan defaults, services like M-Pesa have introduced features that automatically use incoming credits to pay off outstanding loan balances. However, users have reported creating separate mobile money accounts to circumvent this automatic debiting. To deal with issues caused by debt-shaming, digitally savvy users have increasingly begun to offer services helping borrowers repair reputational damage and remove their information from lender databases, charging anywhere from NGN 1,500 to 4,500 (\$0.98–2.93 as of July 2025).⁷¹ These responses to sociodigital exploitation can shape legal frameworks that encourage responsible lending practices from loan companies and increase consumer agency throughout the loan application, disbursement, and repayment process.

Policy Measures for Digital Microlending

Many consumers in African countries are unable to seek recourse against abusive microlending platforms, despite the existence of data protection regulations in the majority of African jurisdictions. Given the lack of policy measures regulating companies operating in this space, many of these companies violate privacy provisions, also highlighting a need for African governments to increase enforcement mechanisms.⁷² In response to many microlending application practices, entities have begun implementing measures to restrict these abusive activities. Google's mobile phone operating system, Android, has an estimated 80 percent market share in Africa,⁷³ which has precipitated many of its actions toward microlending. Actions taken by Google Play, the app store for Android devices, have involved preventing loan apps from accessing

⁷⁰ Ojeniyi, "Nigerians Blackmailed by Loan Apps Are Plotting Revenge in Facebook Groups."

⁷¹ Olaigbe, "Loan Apps Ruined Their Reputations."

⁷² Okolo, "Operationalizing Comprehensive Data Governance in Africa," 200–214.

⁷³ Kaspersky, "The META Region is Among Top-3 Regions Prone to Mobile Financial Scam."

customers' mobile contacts and images and also requiring loan apps in certain jurisdictions (India, Indonesia, Philippines, Nigeria, Kenya, Pakistan, and Thailand) to provide evidence of lending licenses from the respective central banks of these countries.⁷⁴

In Africa, Nigeria leveraged its Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission (FCCPC) to officially register loan apps and also established sanctions against companies in violation. In August 2022, the FCCPC established a digital lending regulatory framework, which officially approved seventy lenders and established a watchlist for offenders.⁷⁵ Similarly, the Kenyan government deregistered loan apps and implemented a formal system requiring loan app companies to register with the Central Bank of Kenya. Since 2022, fifty-eight companies have been granted licenses.⁷⁶ While these efforts will make significant headway in addressing issues associated with digital microlending, much work is needed to improve the enforcement of regulations and compliance with guidelines. While app stores like Google Play and Apple's App Store have enacted several protective measures, advertisements from microlending companies often direct people to download the apps outside of app stores, which removes many of the safeguards these platforms have put in place. Governments also need to implement safeguards for phones that do not have access to standard app stores.⁷⁷

Aside from the lack of regulatory oversight, many microlending apps exhibit serious data privacy concerns, given that these apps extract personal information from users, which is then shared among loan agents working for these companies and leaked online when consumers fail to repay loans. An analysis by the cloud security firm Lookout shows, loan apps operating across countries in the Global South, including three in Africa (Kenya, Nigeria, and Uganda), export personal data collected from app users onto their respective servers after securing device permissions from consumers (Xiong, Dasgupta, and Mambo 2022). While it is claimed that this data is used primarily as a 'behavioral marker' to determine loan eligibility in lieu of formal credit scoring,⁷⁸ many of the harmful practices described in this section rely on the capture and exploitation of this data. To help address many of these issues, African governments should focus on implementing and improving credit scoring systems in addition to increasing partnerships with mobile app store platforms to document consumer complaints. By strengthening enforcement for data privacy protections, which exist in forty-four out of fifty-five African Union member states, data protection offices in African countries can ensure compliance with provisions regarding data localization, storage, and transfer.

⁷⁴ Google Play, "Financial Services."

⁷⁵ FCCPC, "Limited Interim Regulatory/Registration Framework and Guidelines for Digital Lending."

⁷⁶ Central Bank of Kenya, "Seven More Digital Credit Providers Licensed."

⁷⁷ Raywood, "Dodgy Microlending Apps Stalk MEA Users, Highlighting Cyber Maturity Gaps."

⁷⁸ CIPIT, "Privacy and Data Protection Practices of Digital Lending Apps in Kenya."

Toward Just Data and Algorithmic Futures

Consumer subversion of digital microlending platforms parallels existing grassroots movements focused on anticolonial, decolonial, and indigenous approaches to AI development and data governance. The sociodigital exploitation experienced by user interactions with these apps necessitates a new regulatory and analytical paradigm. More broadly, indigenous African philosophical frameworks and cultural values that center on personal accountability and collective prosperity can guide grassroots-driven algorithmic justice measures amid intensifying datafication and algorithmization in the African continent. African indigenous lending practices, such as those discussed earlier, can also reshape the design of microlending apps to encourage responsible loan deployment and ethical debt collection practices. Such design could incorporate community-based approval systems, flexible repayment schedules that align with seasonal income patterns, peer support networks that provide financial counseling and mentorship throughout the loan period, and culturally sensitive communication methods that prioritize respectful dialogue and community mediation over aggressive collection tactics. An increasing number of apps have begun to focus on digitizing these indigenous lending practices, but their adoption pales in comparison to the microlending services offered by larger companies.

Design justice is an approach that advocates for marginalized communities to lead design practices to prevent the reproduction of structural inequalities⁷⁹ and could be used to redesign digital microlending apps to move toward more user-friendly practices. A design justice approach to redesigning microlending apps might involve forming co-design teams led by rural women entrepreneurs, smallholder farmers, or college students who have experienced predatory lending, empowering them to redesign app interfaces in local languages, establish community-controlled interest rate structures, and integrate traditional reciprocal lending mechanisms. However, digital microlending, and lending more broadly, are capitalist endeavors that extend colonial-era exploitation, and lending practices by the World Bank, International Monetary Fund (IMF), and countries like China can be described as ‘neocolonialism.’⁸⁰ Considering these factors, attempting to embed indigenous African practices into these systems may only further entrench colonial ideals. Thus, developing postcolonial digital lending systems to solve issues that have plagued traditional and modern forms of lending and increase user independence from exploitative lending practices could be an ideal path toward collective liberation and an outcome of design justice.

The upsurge of AI adoption and integration will inevitably lead to increasing datafication, which stands to disproportionately impact consumers in African countries

⁷⁹ Costanza-Chock, *Design Justice*.

⁸⁰ Tricontinental, “Life or Debt.”

who suffer from low levels of digital literacy and lack of access to the internet.⁸¹ Multiplying concerns about their existing practices and the many ethical issues present with AI, digital microlending apps also increasingly use AI to aid in credit scoring, assessing credit risk, and tracking customer loan repayments.⁸² Research from Macharia et al. also details how borrowers were unaware of loan terms, including interest rates and repayment processes. These issues are evident in reviewing consumer complaints in app reviews of prominent African digital microlending platforms on the Google Play Store. Along with improving regulatory measures for data privacy protection and microlending practices, African governments must invest in improving consumer financial and digital literacy. While the onus should not be solely on users to protect themselves from dubious microlending apps and similar digital platforms, efforts must be taken to educate users on aspects such as regularly updating apps, downloading apps from verified developers on app stores, and carefully examining permissions requested by downloaded apps.⁸³ Grassroots initiatives, such as online support groups and debt-shaming relief services, could also scale financial and digital literacy efforts, given their extensive adoption across African countries.

As sociodigital exploitation stands to heighten the algorithmic and digital harms faced by African consumers, it will be essential to critically examine the technological infrastructures of digital platforms and understand their influence on society. As marginalized populations within formerly colonized nations contend with the nature of postcolonial discontinuities, there exists a plethora of opportunities to leverage indigenous knowledge and practices to contest, dismantle, and reimagine the adverse effects of datafication and algorithmization in a future racing toward digital dystopianism.

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⁸¹ World Bank, "Digital Transformation Drives Development in Africa."

⁸² Adaramola et al., "Digital Lending."

⁸³ Raywood, "Dodgy Microlending Apps Stalk MEA Users, Highlighting Cyber Maturity Gaps."

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